

Cooperation with the Professional Community Item A: Discuss progress report on LinkedIn page implementation

The AAWS LinkedIn page was launched on November 19, 2019, in English, French, and Spanish. The overall goal of the LinkedIn page is to share information on A.A. with professionals and refer professionals to aa.org.

November 2020 – Trustee’s meeting: Proposed Agenda Item: “That General Service Board expand the use of their existing LinkedIn page for AAWS that fulfills the purposes in accordance with the 2018 Advisory Action.” The proposed Agenda Item was forwarded to the 71 Conference along with the previous background material since 2017 for the LinkedIn Progress Report.

Items to Review:

- Introduction and overall goal
 - Sharing information about AA
 - Visits to the Page during 3 month monitoring
 - 1,00 initial page visits
 - 1,092 CPC Exhibit List
 - Included Statement of AA’s sole purpose
 - provide information on National events with AA volunteer members with booths providing how AA may cooperate with Professionals and where they can find a local AA contact through AAWS at cpc@aa.org.
 - Referring professionals to aa.org
 - Link to aa.org is provided
 - 165 visits during 3-month monitoring
- CPC Exhibit List by month for calendar year
 - City, State, Type of conference and Organization hosting
 - Redirected to AAWS home page; the CPC section
- Expand the Network of our Professional Friends
 - Bring in potential Class A Trustee candidates
 - Version of Box459 with vacancy announcements for non-professional trustee openings
 - Followers feature allows connection with new posts.
 - To date 254 followers have added themselves
- Digital Resources Proposed:
 - Links for Newsletter for Professionals
 - Informational for Professionals page
 - Grapevine/LaVine
 - YouTube: Currently 3 videos from World Service
 - Healthcare
 - Employment/Human Resources
 - Legal & Corrections
- Communications about the LinkedIn Page
 - Announcement to Area, District, Intergroup, CPC chairs, delegates and board trustees and directors along with Grapevine
 - Welcome letter to new CPC chairs
 - *About AA* will include an article about how AA uses technology to carry the AA message and inform professionals
 - *Create Postcard* for CPC exhibits to share LinkedIn page

- *Post Studies* from reputable sources such as JAMA, NIAA NAD SAMHSA...

About LinkedIn:

Potential Professional Contacts: 476 million users of LinkedIn
 138,055 Nurse Practitioners
 90,522 Psychotherapists
 38,160 Addiction Medicine Specialists
 49,754 Probation Officers
 4,443 Parole Board Members
 540,641 People in field of Corrections
 994,100 People in field of Probation
 US Department of Veteran's Affairs 253,840 followers
 Society of Human Resource Management 231,454 followers

Majority Opinion from 2017:

Enhances Cooperation with the professional Community because it:
 Offers Digital accurate information
 Broadens reach *About AA*, a newsletter for Professionals
 Offers Venue for our professional friends to recommend us
 Raises awareness of professional conferences where
 AA will have a presence
 Reinforces relevance and efficacy of our Program
 Expands pool of potential Class A candidates
 Has NO CONFLICT WITH TRADITION 11 *"Moving from Invisibility to the possibility of attraction"*

Minority Opinion from 2017:

CONFLICTS WITH TRADITIONS 6, 10, and 11
 Implied affiliation to advertisements
 Promoting advertising content by presence on page
 Promoting ourselves by being at other organizations' conferences
 Usurps Local contact vs National

Submitted by: Carla Mauldin,
 GSR Local & Conference Liaison Local District 6
Boot Camp: BootCamp March 21, 2021

CPC Item B: Consider a request to create a pamphlet for Mental Health Professionals

71st GSC Agenda Item Summary (pages 203-211)

DESCRIPTION:

In this item, the Conference is being asked to consider the creation of a new AA literature pamphlet that is specifically addressed to mental health professionals.

BACKGROUND:

-In December, 2019, the Area 11 Cooperation with the Professional Community Committee submitted this request for inclusion in the 70th General Service Conference agenda. This agenda item was forwarded to the 71st General Service Conference for consideration.

-The Area 11 CPC Committee states that:

- a. In our current literature, medical professionals are addressed, but that mental health professionals are not specifically addressed.
- b. A new pamphlet, titled for and addressed specifically to mental health professionals will spark their interest and make them more likely to read it.
- c. Many mental health professionals have little knowledge of our program. While they may be aware of what we do, there remains a large amount of misconception and misinformation.

-The Area 11 CPC committee included a list of possible ideas for pamphlet content; however, this information currently falls outside the request under consideration. Also included are prior Trustees' actions related to communication with MHPs, dating back to 1987.

Pros:

1. A pamphlet specifically targeted for mental health professionals increases the chances that this information would be read by them. This will ultimately lead to them being better prepared to help the person who has a desire to stop drinking.
2. If read, the information would help reduce existing misconceptions or misinformation that may exist.

Cons:

1. Cost – the expense of creating and distributing a new pamphlet, as well as the return on investment, is unknown.
2. Evidence is not provided, supporting the idea that having a new pamphlet with a directed title and subject matter would lead to increased readership.
3. Currently, the AA website (aa.org) exhibits 4 existing pamphlets, 1 open letter, and 1 video presentation – all of which addresses information useful for the mental health professional, describing our program, and outlining what AA does and does not do.

(P-46 "If You Are a Professional..."; Open Letter F-2 "Information on Alcoholics Anonymous"; Open Letter F-210 "An Open Letter to Health Care Professionals"; P-23 "AA as a Resource for the Health Care Professional"; Open Letter F-177 "AA as a Resource for Drug and Alcohol Court Professionals". AA.org currently makes the following video presentation: "A.A. Video for Healthcare Professionals.")

4. The question then becomes, "Do we need a new pamphlet, or do we need better ways to reach the target audience?" For example: Is the curious mental health professional going to seek out an AA meeting, or a local Central Office in search of a pamphlet? It is MORE likely they will seek information from the internet. On the homepage of the AA website, aa.org, there is a link titled "Information About AA." Perhaps we could create a new link titled "Information for Mental Health Professionals." This link would direct the mental health professional to helpful information and literature that already exists.

Corrections Item B: Discuss innovative ways of carrying the message to alcoholics in correctional facilities/programs.

Hi, my name is Amy J and I am an alcoholic.

Presenting on Item B for Corrections

Item B: Discuss innovative ways of carrying the message to alcoholics in correctional facilities/programs.

This item is basically a request to hear feedback from your groups about new ways (or even original ways) to carry your group's message to the alcoholics who reside in correctional facilities. Specifically in regards to challenges due to a pandemic.

There are many of us who have that little clue to this puzzle or even pods of members who have been successful. These are people who have been active for months while some, if not most of us have not been seemingly able to carry the message.

A paragraph in the Background Material comes from the group of members who submitted the request for this to be an item to bring to the General Service Conference:

“ Although this year may have created global issues for communication, it has also revealed new opportunities to access the message. As Groups have been finding new ways to hold meetings, work with alcoholics, and participate in the service structure, we have also been finding new ways in which we might reach alcoholics in corrections facilities and programs.”

These conversations and these collective experiences are of soooo much value to our members both inside and outside the correctional facilities.

Also found in the Background Information was a pretty cool list of some of what members were already doing. Imagine if we had the entire Fellowship adding to this list. Imagine being able to bring that new or fairly new member from your Home Group along to watch their Group's message get carried further than their meeting's login and passcode. That there's a solution and a way of life that is soooo GOOD that it blows the roof off any limits a pandemic seemingly puts on your Group. Do you remember the first time you realized AA was much bigger the first meeting you went to?

- When the 2020 pandemic started, Grapevine made available digital access to the it's magazines. This made it possible for female inmates to have access to the many "Meetings In Print."
- Tablets provided by the Correctional Department made it possible for residents to have access to approved AA literature.
- Administrative staff in Southern Minnesota assisted in establishing video conferencing with AA members.
- Corrections Committee CHairs have supplied all chaplains with AA literature. WOW, how did they do that!?!

We know about these here because it's accessible in the Background Information for this year's conference. Imagine if all of our United States and Canada groups all shared their ideas and even their experience with what worked for them in carrying the message in 2020 and 2021.

Item B in Corrections is asking us to have a discussion... to go back to our groups and have the conversations. To collect back feedback from what was shared and bring them to the Conference through our Delegate.

OK, I have one minute to wrap up...

The Background Material/Information on this item is found on page 244-249. Our Area 09 has access to this material and our Delegate just shared how to access this information and made himself available if we needed any more assistance in getting to it.

I realize that of all of us here today (130+ members so far), let alone in the US and Canada are not going to read all the material. We might have showed up to this Bootcamp so we could get the gist of what is written there. I relate. I did that too in the beginning. However, after a few of these Bootcamps I noticed I was only getting just a pitch. Imagine being seated at an AA restaurant and the AA waiter comes by and asks you if you would like to hear about today's special and that waiter gives you a beautiful but brief description of what that dish is. If we just said "Yes, that sounds great!" we may end up selling ourselves short of a Spiritual Experience. We have all the permissions to get up from that table, go into the kitchen and ask questions... to taste the sauce to learn something about what is making it a special. Imagine now coming back to the table and sharing what we just experienced. Our members with us at the table all drooling, then jumping up and running back to the kitchen to go learn for themselves. Imagine waiting at the table for them to hurry up already! And they do come back and discuss and you all make an informed group decision. What an experience... what a meal.

Pages 248 and 249 are a special kind of meal. Please take a look at it. Share it with your groups or committees. Discuss what you learned, concerns, or excitement. Come back to the table and each order your meals.

Thank you. My name is Amy and I am an alcoholic.

Literature Item B: Consider request to revise the book Alcoholics Anonymous Forwarded from the 70th GSC

1. Add pages 3 through 41 of the pamphlet "The A.A. Group" as an appendix to the next printing.
2. Revise the first 164 pages.

Item #1 - adding pages 3 through 41 of the pamphlet "The A.A. Group" as an appendix to the next printing of the Big Book was originally put forward for consideration to the 70th GSC by a member in Area 13.

Pro: In their letter to the Conference Coordinator, the Area 13 delegate explained that it was their belief that having the pamphlet in the appendix would encourage best practices and participation in General Service, due to the fact that many groups read from the text, Alcoholics Anonymous. Ultimately, improving our service culture to the benefit of the groups, the still suffering alcoholic, and AA as a whole.

Con: Possible increase cost to add another appendix. The pamphlets are already readily available to the groups. AA has many great pamphlets and they cant all be added to the back of the book.

Item#2

District 55 proposal to revise the first 164 pages of the Big Book:

Proposal:

The Conference form a study committee to audit the first 164 pages of the BIG BOOK with the purpose of identifying changes that can be made to make the BIG BOOK more reflective of the AA membership composition. The focus on the following for possible change

1. Pronoun Usage - Where possible the gender -neutral form
2. Passages or sections that are no longer consistent with or relevant when taken in context of society in general or the AA membership composition
3. The chapters TO Wives and The Family Afterward should specifically be evaluated for revisions to be more consistent with today's membership

Changes to the overall message should be avoided. Simplification of the vocabulary should not be considered

References to historical figures and events should remain unchanged.

Suitable changes should be suggested by the study committee and subject to Conference approval.

Examples of possible changes consistent with the proposal:

1. Pronoun usage himself to themselves (pg 17 "But the ex-problem drinker who has found this solution, who is properly armed with facts about himself (themselves)
2. Excerpts of a passage revised for relevance to society and AA membership composition From Into Action page 80

The chances are we have domestic troubles. Perhaps we are mixed up with women (someone) In a fashion we wouldn't care to have advertised....After a few years with an alcoholic, a wife (a spouse) gets worn out, resentful and uncommunicative...The husband (alcoholic) begins to feel sorry for himself (themselves). ...A man (A person) so involved often feels very remorseful at times, especially if they are married to a loyal and courageous girl (partner) who has literally gone through hell with them.

3. Chapters: Revisions to the chapters To Wives and The Family Afterward and perhaps even To Employers are challenging. The proposal includes the caveat that it is outside the scope of the proposal to address what may be done specifically. However, Historical references to people or events should remain the same. Two examples are Bill's Story and the proposal of travel to the moon in We Agnostics, which is characterized as an idea we cannot know with certainty, should remain unchanged.

- The proposal has been made specific in order to clarify the objective. This proposal is NOT an attempt to make a simple-language Big Book.
- The proposal leaves the identification and development of changes, and the subsequent approval process up to the Conference to determine.
- 1995 conference advisory action preventing changes to the first 164 pages remains in effect. That would need to be amended before any changes could be made.

BACKGROUND:

A third party audit of our ability to effectively send, receive, and share information both inside the fellowship and with key external constituencies discovered "There are significant challenges in communications that are negatively impacting AA's relevance, and impeding its effectiveness in reaching the still-suffering alcoholic."

It is not the intention of the proposal to remove all reference to gender. Nor is it a proposal about a plain-language or simplified language big book.

Instead the focus is to modernize the Big Book to reflect the fact that 38% of AA members are women. To produce a general shift to be more inclusive and references of women subservient to men be addressed. That social attitude, women being subservient, has nothing to do with getting sober anyway. Further, redevelopment of sections that have lost much of their relevance such as To Employers, To Wives and The Family Afterward, or perhaps complete replacement might be achievable as well.

PRO's

- By addressing our ability to stay relevant, we will better be able to carry the message to the still suffering alcoholic
- Conclusions from the Communication Audit by the third party suggests not addressing the issue with the first 164 pages will have a negative impact
- This is an issue that will not improve over time.

CON'S

- The 1986 Advisory Actions pertaining to sexist language in the Big Book and other Bill W. writings adequately address the issue:
 - The preface of the Big Book clearly state the text was written 1939 and that it has largely not been changed"
 - We continue to degenderize AA literature with the exception of Bill W's writings such that our relevance and inclusion is handled with the language we update in the pamphlets.
- The 1995 Advisory Action that the first 164 pages of the Big Book, The Preface, the Forwards, The Doctor's Opinion, Doctor Bob's Nightmare and the Appendices remain as is is still in effect.

Literature Item C: Consider proposals related to possible 5th Edition of the book Alcoholics Anonymous

1. Read the topic itself and explain what it is, give a brief description of what is being asked of the conference to do.

A. Consider proposals related to possible Fifth Edition of the book Alcoholics

Anonymous:

1. Develop a Fifth Edition.
2. Develop a Fifth Edition of the book Alcoholics Anonymous with updated stories and revisions to
 - a. Appendix III (The Medical View on AA), quotes a NBC broadcast in 1946 and a paper from 1949
 - b. Appendix V (The Religious View on AA), Edward Dowling died in 1960, Harry Fosdick died in 1969
3. Add a proposed addendum to a Fifth Edition foreword of the book Alcoholics Anonymous at the time it is published.

1. Read all the background info and make bullet points of the most important reasons why this topic was created. Some examples would be high points from letters from the group to the area as to why they think the topic is important, past experience of an AA member and why they think the topic is pertinent, any history on the topic especially if it has been an agenda topic at previous conferences, (you'll find that with the amount of money that can be contributed and whether the GV Gray pages should be removed/added back in).

A. Area 06, California Northern Coastal → That the Trustees' Literature Committee add to its agenda to consider publishing a Fifth Edition of the Big Book, Alcoholics Anonymous, with updated stories to more broadly reflect our current fellowship , as well as updates or additions to Appendices III and V”

B. Timeline of our book

1. The First Edition was published in 1939
2. 16 years later came the Second Edition was published in 1955
3. 21 years later came the Third Edition was published in 1976
4. 25 years later came the Fourth Edition was published in 2001

C. District 52 Area 20 feels that the stories in the Big Book “need to reflect our changing society to reach the still suffering. If the alcoholic cannot identify with any of the stories due to the age of the stories that alcoholic may continue to suffer. We have an obligation, stated in the Traditions, to reach the still suffering. For the alcoholic to identify the stories need to reflect the current socio-economic experiences of the average person. As the last edition was published in 2001, and there have been vast changes in our society over the intervening years, there are no stories that reflect the current societal experience.”

3. List the Pros and Cons of the topic, remembering how it affects AA as a whole, not just you and your group. Most agenda topics have the pros and cons listed, you can use those and any other pros/cons you may think are pertinent.

A. Pros:

1. It has been 20 years since our last BB update, since it takes time to make the update (7 years for the 4th edition) it is time we talk about it
2. This is conservative change and likely to pass our membership
3. Cheaper than some of the other options to change the big book.
4. New edition will bump sales
5. New stories will help connect to new members
6. New stories will help modernize the book

7. A modern view of religion and medicine will help reflect the current views on mental illness & medication
 8. Could include people who got sober during covid/via online meetings and the use of technology in sobriety.
 9. Update the appendix v to include other than
- B. Cons:
1. This request doesn't go far enough to speak to our changing/diverse membership and changing society.
 2. Our BB is not accessible to all and this change will not make the updates to help make this accessible.
 3. The expense to make this happen.
 4. If we are investing in a 5th edition, changes should be different enough to warrant the cost.
 5. New stories that reflect current society are available in The Grapevine and La Vina.
 6. Moving forward with a 5th edition sets a precedent that the book needs to be updated every ~20 years and creates an opportunity for the essence of the BB to drastically change over time.
 7. AA invests in pamphlets to provide updated information on religion, medicine, mental illness, medication, etc. so this is already available.
 8. There are already 2 proposed items on the Trustees committee on literature; this one will be more noise.
 9. We are still in global pandemic and literature sales have significantly decreased. Without knowing what AA will look like over the next year, this is too large an undertaking financially.

Literature Item: D. - Consider development of a draft Fourth Edition of the book Alcohólicos Anónimos.

A little bit of History:

We are currently on the 3rd edition of the Spanish Language AA text. The 3rd edition was proposed at the 2004 General Service conference. The first 164 pages of the Big Book, the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Dr. Bob's Nightmare," and the Appendices underwent a complete review to assure accuracy of translation and consistency of style and tone throughout the text. Another big change to the 3rd edition was the Personal Stories section and by the time the 3rd edition was finished there were roughly 176 stories which had been submitted by people from all over the world.

The 3rd edition was created over the next several years. The Trustee's literature committee continued to work on developments and translation corrections as well as selection of the personal stories section that was also under review.

At 2007 General Service conference the final report and 3rd edition draft was shared with the conference and it was approved. Soon after, the newly revised 3rd edition went into publication. **As in translations of all languages, the Publications Department strives to reflect the best possible translation of Bill W.'s writings but the translation does not require Conference approval.**

The 3RD edition subcommittee noted that the past practices of developing translations of the Big Book into Spanish and French have been as varied as the population for whom the literature was created.

This brings us to where we are today.

Over the last several years, AA World Service has received several requests for corrections be made to perceived “errors” in translation and perceived “omissions” in the translated Spanish Big Book. I had the opportunity to speak to/interview Jesus, the past Area 9 delegate, who brought this motion to a floor action at the 2019 General Service conference, and he mentioned a man named Adolpho from Area 3 in AZ who has, for some time discussed the errors in translation currently present in the 3rd edition of the text. Adolpho compiled a list of recommendations of changes that he and other members felt should be made to the 3rd edition. While he did submit requests for revisions in 2015 and 2017, he did not submit any kind of agenda item and did not adopt the idea of a 4th edition of the text, he wanted to revise the 3rd edition. He made a list of corrections he and others had discussed and sent them to GSO. He asked past and present delegates what they thought and while they agreed there were mistakes, no motions were made, or actions taken at that time. As Jesus, our area 9 Delegate, was getting ready to attend the 2019 general service conference, he was approached by a man named Melquiades V. from District 20, who told Jesus that many Spanish speaking members in his district and Area were adamant about getting an agenda item to the conference regarding the translation errors in 3rd edition of the text. He recommended that Jesus propose a 4th edition of the book. The translation errors, grammar mistakes and any other matters pertaining to the text could be discussed in a subcommittee if the 4th edition agenda item could be passed. Because agenda items need to be sent in by Dec. 15th prior to the conference (which is in April every year) for approval and it was just days away from the conference, Jesus decided to submit this item as a floor action. Which is a very exciting process. Floor action items are items that have not been approved as agenda items but are often items that a delegate feels are in the best interest of their area and may not have had time to submit for approval. Jesus quickly wrote a floor action request, submitted it to the conference coordinator when he got to New York in 2019, and it was approved for a floor action motion. Jesus then took the item to the floor of the conference, proposing a 4th edition of the book be created. A gentleman named Dee P., who at the time was the AZ Area 03 delegate, was a great help in getting the motion pushed through by way of advisory action after the committee tabled discussion on the 2019 Conference floor action. This advisory action was as follows: “That the proposed floor action ‘A draft of a Fourth Edition of the Spanish Big Book, Alcohólicos Anónimos, be developed and a progress report be brought to the 2020 General Service Conference”. In 2020, because of the COVID 19 Pandemic and the limited amount of time due to the Conference being online, only 3 or 4 literature agenda items were voted on last year, leaving many of the agenda items to be forwarded to the 2021 conference. This is one of those items. As you can see in the history of the 3rd edition creation, this is not an overnight matter, and continues for multiple years. This agenda item is the beginning of an extensive process of revisions and translation corrections - amongst other things, which will be decided on, should this agenda item be voted on and approved at the 2021 General Service conference next month.

So, with all that said, do you and your groups believe it is time to consider a 4th Edition of the Spanish Language Big Book, Alcohólicos Anónimos?

Literature Item E: Consider requests to revise the book *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*

1. To remove the phrase “opposite sex” from paragraph two on page 117 in the chapter “Step Twelve.”
2. To reconsider use of the phrase “lustful enough to rape” in paragraph one on page 66 in the chapter “Step Six.”

+ Forwarded from the 70th G.S.C.

- In May 2019, a group in District 1, Area 15 discussed the language of the paragraph at its business meeting and unanimously voted to create a group conscious to propose the change to remove the words “of the opposite sex.”

- The District 1, Area 15 DCM submitted a letter to the GSO Conference Coordinator in July 2019 with the following points being made:
 - Clearly the paragraph conflicts with Tradition 10. It states that every sound human desires to find a mate of the opposite sex with whom the fullest union can be made, and it says that “God fashioned us that way.” This reflects religious ideals & AA has no opinion on outside affiliations, let alone stating God's will towards sexual preferences.
 - Tradition 3 tells us that the only requirement for membership is the desire to stop drinking. Telling any alcoholic that their lifestyle preference is not sound or that it goes against God's Will, says to them that they're different, and could have them question if they're accepted in the fellowship.
 - Tradition 2 tells us, for our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority-a LOVING god as He may express himself in our group conscience.
- After removing the words “of the opposite sex” the new paragraph would read: “Nearly every sound human being experience's, at some time in life, a compelling desire to find a mate with whom the fullest possible union can be made - spiritual, mental, emotional, and physical. The mighty urge is the root of great human accomplishments, a creative energy that deeply influences our lives. God fashioned us that way...” (The rest of the paragraph would remain unchanged.)
- In a second letter, Area 15 District 1 DCM brought about a motion to remove the phrase “of the opposite sex” to the August District 1 Business meeting to be brought back to the groups by the GSRs to discuss.
- At the next District Business Meeting in September, some of the comments during discussion were as follows:
- **Against:** If we start changing anything, where would we stop? and That as written, the 12x12 was good enough to get them sober, so it is good enough for everyone
- **For:** The removal of the few words would be inclusive, it was religious in nature, some members were personally offended by the text as written.

E 2. To reconsider use of the phrase “lustful enough to rape” in paragraph one on page 66 in the chapter “Step Six.

- In July 2019, a group in District 15, Area 07 submitted a request to remove the phrase “lustful enough to rape” stating the following reasons:
 - Lust is not the cause of rape. The cause of rape is complex and multifaceted. In a 2015 literary review on the causes of rape, Beverly A. M. concludes that "rape occurs due to multiple motives rather than [a] single motivation ... The multiple motivations include, but are not limited to sexual gratification, revenge, recreation, power/control, and attempts to achieve or perform masculinity and a desire for power, among other causes". In stating so plainly that lust leads to rape, these words are hugely misleading. This inaccuracy at best misinforms AA members and at worst triggers AA members--many of whom are sexual assault survivors.
 - The causes of sexual assault were not studied, well-known, or understood when Bill W. wrote that sentence. We owe it to all the people in Alcoholics Anonymous who have experienced sexual assault in any way to be accurate and supportive in our mention or discussion of this issue.
 - Use of the word's "rape" or "sexual assault" in one of our main pieces of literature, the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions, is unnecessary. Words that have such potential to provoke trauma belong in literature that's more narrowly focused, like pamphlets.

- Area 07, discussed and passed this proposed change to the 12x12 with substantial unanimity and informed the Conference Committee via their delegate in December 2019.
- 2002 Conference Advisory Action - "The text in the book, *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, written by Bill W., remain as is, recognizing the Fellowship's feeling that Bill's writings be retained as originally published."
- **Pros:** If it will help one more person why not implement the change
- removing these items would be potentially removing what some may consider borderline political issues.
- It helps with inclusivity.
- **Cons:** what this change would cost through the whole process.
- It can open the door to much more changes.

In speaking with several members of the program on this item I have heard many different views such as "I feel like when bill wrote it he was using the most extreme/drastring of examples and if that's the case why not change angry enough to murder as well because murder is not necessarily from anger and so on the list would go", "I am not worried about because I already have sobriety and solution in my life and if it will help someone new that is my responsibility". I can keep going as this has been a hot topic and anything related to literature at that tends to spark discussions. I will say It has been a gift to watch so many discuss these items some with wealth of knowledge and read all the material and some merely personal opinions but through healthy discussion, respect for one another, keeping an open mind and being willing to listen rather than need to speak, reminding myself that I am a small part of a huge whole, I have been able to change some of my own views and that's the beauty of all this so thank you for allowing me to be of service.

Isaac M., District 5 Alt. DCMC

Literature Item I: "Consider revising the pamphlet Questions & Answers on Sponsorship"

My name is Tommy D, I am an alcoholic and a GSR from District 12 Area 9. I will be presenting Literature Item I: "Consider revising the pamphlet Questions & Answers on Sponsorship". Specifically, "Change the suggestion that sponsor and newcomer be of the same sex" and "Expand the section on 'Service Sponsorship' and retitle the pamphlet to include service sponsorship". Both parts of this Item were forwarded by the trustees' Literature Committee from last year's 70th General Service Conference.

Starting with the first motion of Item I, which was made by Eric T. of the T.R.A.N.S. (Transgender Recovering Alcoholic Navigating Sobriety) group of A.A. from New York. The complete motion states:

I move that the pamphlet Questions & Answers on Sponsorship be updated to remove the suggestion that sponsor and newcomer be of the same sex.

Specifically, the following paragraph, found on page 12 under the heading "Can any member be a sponsor?" [which reads]: In most instances, A.A. custom does suggest one limitation, already noted on page 10: If the group is large

enough to allow a choice, sponsor and newcomer be of the same sex. The reasons are the same from both viewpoints; we A.A. members, no matter how long we have been sober, remain thoroughly human, subject to emotions that might divert us from “our primary purpose”.

be updated as read: A. A. custom does suggest one limitation: sponsorship should be avoided wherever a romantic entanglement might arise between sponsor and newcomer. We A.A. members, no matter how long we have been sober, remain thoroughly human, subject to emotions that might divert us from “our primary purpose”.

According to the background information provided by Eric T. this proposal calls for an alteration of the language in the pamphlet to state the intended message without excluding some members of our fellowship. As Eric puts it, a vital practice in our message is sponsorship, and the literature as it is written results in disproportionate access to sponsorship for transgender or nonbinary alcoholics. Nonbinary people do not identify as either men or women. Eric shares about the systemic barriers within A.A. and other specific problems that commonly arise in the process of finding a sponsor for trans or nonbinary newcomers. Eric suggests that the pamphlet on sponsorship directing alcoholics to seek and work with sponsors of the same sex is reinforcing the barriers and consequences experienced by trans and nonbinary alcoholics. Eric reasons that “[o]ur pamphlets are routinely updated to reflect new information and to try to enhance the inclusivity of the fellowship wherever possible. Small changes in these areas may be enough to save the lives of transgender and nonbinary alcoholics”.

Certainly, many if not all A.A. members are aware of the value of sponsorship. Perhaps not as ubiquitous, but more specific to those of us here today, is an understanding of service sponsorship. Our second recommendation is brought to us from Area 44. The recommendation reads as:

“To help carry the message of the importance of A.A. service, and to reinforce the idea that service is for every A.A. member; it is recommended that the Service Sponsorship section in the pamphlet Questions & Answers on Sponsorship (P-15) be expanded, and that the pamphlet be retitled to include Service Sponsorship — and that this recommendation be forwarded to the Conference Coordinator for inclusion in the 2020 General Service Conference agenda.

In 2017, Northern New Jersey Area 44 submitted a request: that the Conference consider developing and writing a pamphlet on Service Sponsorship. The item made its way through the proper channels but was ultimately not included on the conference agenda, with the conference literature committee stating that as they put it: “there was no express need from the Fellowship”. Area 44 continues to push for the recommendation because they “consider service sponsorship to be of great importance and ... many other Areas share the importance of having a service sponsor as a guide”.

After continued discussion on the item, Jay E. a past delegate from Panel 65 Area 44 suggested instead that it would be best to expand the current sponsorship pamphlet. According to Jay, “research found a scarcity of information on Service Sponsorship”. The only two existing literature items being: one service piece titled Sponsorship — A Vital Stepping-Stone to Service and Sobriety, and the pamphlet Questions & Answers on Sponsorship. To the point of retitling the pamphlet, Jay offers that “the title could ... be something like: ‘Questions & Answers on Sponsorship and Service Sponsorship’ or ‘Questions & Answers on Sponsorship: Recovery and Service’. Eventually, Jay E. puts forth a compelling point by explaining how in most cases if we “ask any A.A. member about sponsorship ... invariably they will answer about recovery sponsorship — in fact many A.A. members are completely unfamiliar with the term Service Sponsor”.

Of course, all of the information provided today comes from A.A.’s who wish to see change. What is most important is that now you — as equal members in this program without leaders — do your part in asking your groups some important questions. Do you think this will take away from our message? Is this necessary or desirable? Will this help carry the message? And will this positively impact A.A.? Thank you.

Literature Item J: Consider request to include a GSR Preamble in the pamphlet “GSR: Your Group’s Link to AA as a Whole”

Description of Literature Item J (pages 593-596)

Literature Item J is a proposal to revise the G.S.R. pamphlet, entitled *G.S.R.: Your Group’s Link to A.A. as a Whole*, by adding the “G.S.R. Preamble” to the pamphlet.

No other revisions are suggested. The G.S.R Preamble reads:

We are the General Service Representatives. We are the link in the chain of communication for our groups with the General Service Conference and the world of A.A. We realize the ultimate authority is a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience. As trusted servants, our job is to bring information to our groups in order that they can reach an informed group conscience. In passing along this group conscience, we are helping to maintain the unity and strength so vital to our fellowship. Let us, therefore, have the patience and tolerance to listen while others share, the

courage to speak up when we have something to share, and the wisdom to do what is right for our group and A.A. as a whole.

Background on Literature Item J

Literature Item J was proposed by a group from Belleview, Illinois (Southern Ill. Area 21) for the 70th G.S.C. The T.L.C. reviewed/agreed to forward the item to the 71st G.S.C.

According to the proponent, the G.S.R. Preamble was written circa 1975. In 1988, a Palm Springs intergroup newsletter printed the G.S.R. Preamble. The G.S.O. took notice of the use of the G.S.R. Preamble at some meetings, and in the Aug./Sept. 1989 issue of Box 459, commented as follows: "Since G.S.R.s are frequently hailed as the 'guardians of the Traditions,' it is appropriate that the preamble emphasizes the importance of an informed group conscience in maintaining strength and unity."¹

The proponent of Item J asserts that adding the G.S.R. Preamble to the pamphlet will benefit AA by: (1) providing "a clear-cut directive to G.S.R.s regarding their responsibility;" (2) providing "consistency and thus unity across A.A. as a whole;" and (3) bestowing "conference-approved literature" status the G.S.R. Preamble.

According to the proponent, a 2009 proposal to add the G.S.R. Preamble to the Service Manual resulted in no action taken, and no other proposals concerning the G.S.R. Preamble have been presented to the G.S.C.

Pros of Literature Item J: See above for the 3 benefits claimed by the proponents.

Cons of Literature Item J:

- (1) Expense is presumably high relative to benefit;
- (2) Lack of necessity – existing literature outlines the full responsibilities of the G.S.R.;
- (3) Might erroneously imply that facilitating an informed group conscience is the sole or primary responsibility of a G.S.R., when in fact that is one of many responsibilities.

¹ See https://www.aa.org/newsletters/en_US/en_box459_aug-sept89.pdf, at p. 7

Literature Item U: Consider if proposed agenda items for the plain language, simplified language, accessible translations and large print version of the book *Alcoholics Anonymous*, as well as workbooks to help study the program of Alcoholics Anonymous, can be addressed with a common solution.

MANYA Literature ITEM U: We are considering if the proposed agenda items for plain language, simplified language, accessible translations and large print versions of the book *Alcoholics Anonymous*, as well as workbooks to help study the program of Alcoholics Anonymous, can be addressed with a common solution.

MANYA Action Items:

The video providing information about concerns that may lead to a plain language Big Book is at:

<https://vimeopro.com/user112910871/big-book-riptab/video/500617913>

Background Information (approximately 128 pages):

- **PAUL** "Consider Development of a Plain Language version of the Big Book" came out of Area 78 (Canada) – Panel 64; it was subsequently forwarded to the 2016 conference committee on literature.
- **Since then**, the trustees' Literature Committee (TLC) continued exploring IF proposed agenda items (**14 total that overlap – see page 824 of background material**) related to the *accessibility, relevancy, and relatability* of the Big Book CAN BE addressed with a common solution. The 14 overlapping items are:
 - (1) creation of 5th edition from 69th conference;
 - (2). proposed changes to Big Book or 5th edition to

reflect the current member composition at 70th and 71st conference; (3). Development of interpretive tools (i.e. AA dictionaries); (4). Proposed workbooks or study guides; (5). New material presenting program of recovery in plain language of digital formats.

- The committee noted that the video presentation “The Big Book: Researching Issues, Possible Tools and Access (70th General Service Conference 2020),” which was presented to the Conference Committee on Literature during their May 2, 2020 agenda reduction meeting.
 - Note: This video was to be presented at the 70th GSC, but pandemic hit, and only essential business was discussed.
- **PAUL** Therefore, the best new information available to talk about *accessibility, relevancy, and relatability* of the current Big Book is given in the 21-minute video available at: <https://vimeopro.com/user112910871/big-book-riptab/video/500617913> (IF POSSIBLE, WE CAN POST THIS VIDEO TO THE CHAT)
- Issues that arose driving the 14 agenda items: literacy, other access barriers, gender, secular, modern vernacular (linguistic), cultural references, professional content/audience impact.

Definitions for clarification (Manya can discuss)

- **Accessibility comports with tradition 3 – no other requirement necessary other than to stay sober. Some accessibility barriers include: to the Big Book • Education • Incarceration • Race & ethnicity • Reading disabilities • English first language • Brain injuries or other processing disabilities.**
 - The average reading level of inmates is low. One study estimated 5th grade level. It is important to differentiate between reading level and literacy level, which is also low among inmates. Literacy encompasses all the skills needed for reading and writing including vocabulary, comprehension, and being able to assimilate and analyze what is read. Members on the outside have easier access to sponsors who can help them understand the Big Book.
- **Relatability** includes changes in current language and culture (including views on modern language, gender and religion) which hinder the individual’s ability to relate and embrace the program as set forth in the book Alcoholics Anonymous.
- **MANYA** History of the RIBTAB Submcom:
 - **In the last few years years, at least 3-5 proposed GSC agenda items are received each year relating updating or changing the big book. The TLC discussed plans for continued exploration of the topics which were presented in the background for the 2020 Conference Committee on Literature.** The chair appointed a subcommittee comprised of 3 people to: 1. Determine the specific literacy level of the Big Book, Alcoholics Anonymous. 2. Continue exploring how non Conference-approved literature (i.e. such as the Akron pamphlets, Little Red Book, Big Book dictionary) is being utilized by A.A. members to carry the message for the purpose of better addressing any perceived gaps and their solutions at the local level for accessibility and relatability to the program of Alcoholics Anonymous. 3. Request additional input on this topic from other trustees’ committees in 2020 on this topic, including but not limited to Public Information, Corrections and Treatment and Accessibilities committees. 4. Undertake any other areas of exploration as they become identified.
 - Thus, increased frequency, overlap, and clarity of items prompted the subcommittee: The subcommittee looking into the plain language and other issues relative to the Big Book is called the RIPTAB: “Researching Issues, Possible Tools and Access to the Book, Alcoholics Anonymous.”

- The subcommittee reviewed recent and current fellowship agenda items (14 total), and found compelling strength and possibility in **two approaches/solutions** to impact barriers related to accessibility, relevancy, and relatability. These approaches focus on the development of **(1) multi-media digital material and (2) plain language content**.

(Out of page 828-829):

Of the many potential solutions to the accessibility and relatability agenda items in recent years, RIPTAB II found compelling strength and possibility in two agenda item approaches that appear promising in their potential reach while maintaining the integrity of the message. Here we share some comments to illustrate why we feel that further study is warranted. If prudent, the trustees' Committee on Literature might request input from the Conference Committee on Literature and the AA Fellowship on these approaches, submitted by the Fellowship across numerous agenda items.

Solution 1: *Development of digital material related to the message of recovery (#13 above; agenda item currently in TLC).* This agenda item proposed development of multi-media platforms to share historical and current perspectives related to BB content. This digital content would not be intended to replace or translate the Big Book, but rather to supplement access to the message through a multi-media platform. Such projects might include visual/video interviews; podcasts; graphic illustrations or animation. In considering such dynamic material, it was thought that such a project might be best curated through the AAGV, but with the GSC providing guidance, structure, and vision. By seating the project in the AAGV, dynamic and ongoing content could be accessed from historical material and created via avenues already piloted in some manner (submissions, review, archiving). We recognize that the GSC and GSB would need to authorize and direct such a novel AAGV endeavor.

Solution 2: The Fellowship has repeatedly indicated a desire or need for a new *plain language written book, not meant to replace the big book but instead to break through access and relatability barriers*. Persistent and widespread need appears to be demonstrated. Such a plain text is conceptualized as an entirely new item, rather than a replacement, designed to be relatable and understandable at very basic literacy levels. Formats that could be considered: i. Simple plain text content reflecting the Big Book text, a plain language reader. ii. Workbook format: Brief introductions, sharing on each principle and questions to prompt self-examination and/or work with a sponsor. Example: Reaching for Personal Freedom, Al-anon's workbook for steps, traditions, and concepts. iii. Study Guide format: In depth chapters on each step, tradition, and concept, with sharing and questions at the end of each. Example: Pathways to Recovery. Fundamentally, the format is secondary to the idea that there is value to using plain language for comprehension and relatability. If shared experience is included, it should be illustrative rather than directive in nature. Our pamphlets do just this, editorial content is supplemented by examples or illustrations of the concepts. Such a plain language reader could be formatted similarly (like a giant pamphlet with a hardcover).

Neither of these approaches would be designed to replace or supplant the current text Alcoholics Anonymous (Note: the RIPTAB II report on pages 813-830 of the background material

PROS (Paul) (p. 826-830 of background)

- Accessibility, relevancy, inclusiveness, and equity of our program; Language may change to be accessible to all, but it will not change the meaning.

- One point of contention is that a sponsor can just help the sponsee with the words of the book (using aids, etc). However, having a sponsor help someone is great, but not always available to everyone in prisons, treatment facilities, remote communities, etc,

CONS (Paul):

- The current book includes a love for the current language as it relates to successful recovery. Some think changes are threatening while others will believe that it will alter the program.
 - **Caution from background material:** Any work related to accessibility, whether by addition of footnotes-forwards-appendices or development of new material, should take painstaking care to not fundamentally eliminate or shift the basic tenants of the recovery program.
- Use of literacy aids to help understand current material may hinder those who have little to access to education, tutoring , and support. These kinds of aids may be awkward or foreign to some.

MANYA Takeaway: This idea of a new book is not meant to replace the Big Book, rather to overcome relatability and accessibility barriers so the A.A. message might reach more still-suffering alcoholics. (Background notes, p. 702)

PAUL Question(s) for Area: Please see the above-referenced video under the Confidential Information under the Delegate link, and provide your feedback on the video, and specifically, on your input about pursuing (or not) the Plain Language Big Book as an Agenda Item at the 2021, 71st Conference of A.A.

MANYA Question(s) for Area from page 312 (pg. 808 of background): (1) Should the Trustees' Literature Committee explore possible solutions that could help make our message more available? (2) If so, what additional information would be helpful to determine if additional items are needed to increase accessibility and relatability to the A.A. program? (3) Would a translation into modern or simple language help? (4) And, What tools would help others understand our program of recovery? Workbooks? Dictionaries?

Literature Item V: Consider adding the Long Form of each Tradition at the beginning of each essay for that Tradition in the book, Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions

Item V. Introduced by: Gerry M AA Member, Area 72, District 46 in the state of Washington

Consider adding the Long Form of each Tradition at the beginning of each essay for that Tradition in the book, *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*.

What is forgotten and not read is the long form of the Tradition, buried in the back of the book. Please remedy this by printing the long form of each Tradition at the beginning of each essay with or without the blurb. The long form is where I find great guidance for dealing with issues that come up in recovery and in service. **It is my observation that the long form is far too under-utilized and unknown to too many AA members and making them more visible in this much studied book would help.** And making this change in addition to any other revisions makes sense financially since a reprint would take place anyway.

Pros:

Increased familiarity with the long form of the 12 Traditions

Cons:

The expense of the book revision.

The content of the long form of each tradition is addressed in the essay that follows the tradition.

There are other ways to familiarize AA members to the long form of the 12 Traditions.

THE TWELVE TRADITIONS (Short Form / Long Form)

1. Our common welfare should come first; personal recovery depends upon AA unity.

1. - Each member of Alcoholics Anonymous is but a small part of a great whole. A.A. must continue to live or most of us will surely die. Hence our common welfare comes first. But individual welfare follows close afterward.

[All aspects of the long form of tradition one are addressed in the essay.](#)

2. For our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority—a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience. Our leaders are but trusted servants; they do not govern

2. - For our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority—a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience.

[The short form of the second tradition is actually longer than the long form of tradition two. The essay addresses the content of both versions.](#)

3. The only requirement for AA membership is a desire to stop drinking.

3. - Our membership ought to include all who suffer from alcoholism. Hence we may refuse none who wish to recover. Nor ought A.A. membership ever depend upon money or conformity. Any two or three alcoholics gathered together for sobriety may call themselves an A.A. group, provided that, as a group, they have no other affiliation. [All aspects of the long form of tradition three are addressed in the essay.](#)

4. Each group should be autonomous except in matters affecting other groups or AA as a whole.

4. - With respect to its own affairs, each A.A. group should be responsible to no other authority than its own conscience. But when its plans concern the welfare of neighboring groups also, those groups ought to be consulted. And no group, regional committee, or individual should ever take any action that might greatly affect A.A. as a whole without conferring with the trustees of the General Service Board. On such issues our common welfare is paramount.

[All aspects of the long form of tradition four are addressed in the essay.](#)

5. Each group has but one primary purpose—to carry its message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

5. - Each Alcoholics Anonymous group ought to be a spiritual entity having but one primary purpose—that of carrying its message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

[The essay initially refers to the group as individuals with a significant purpose. Then it identifies the group members \(as individuals\) carrying the message to the still suffering alcoholic. The group member brings the concept of spirituality to their prospect in a non-threatening way. The long form is addressed in the essay.](#)

6. An AA group ought never endorse, finance, or lend the AA name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property and prestige divert us from our primary purpose.

6. - Problems of money, property, and authority may easily divert us from our primary spiritual aim. We think, therefore, that any considerable property of genuine use to AA should be separately incorporated and managed, thus dividing the material from the spiritual. An A.A. group, as such, should never go into business. Secondary aids to A.A., such as clubs or hospitals which require much property or administration, ought to be incorporated and so set apart that, if necessary, they can be freely discarded by the groups. Hence such facilities ought not to use the A.A. name. Their management about be the sole responsibility of those people who financially support them. For clubs, A.A. managers are usually preferred. But hospitals, as well as other places of recuperation, ought to be well outside A.A. -- medically supervised. While an A.A. group may cooperate with anyone, such cooperation ought never go so far as affiliation or endorsement, actual or implied. An A.A. group can bind itself to no one.

The content addressed in the long form of tradition six is CLEARLY covered in the essay for tradition six. No aspect of the long form is omitted from the essay.

7. Every AA group ought to be fully self supporting declining outside contributions.

7. - The A.A. groups themselves ought to be fully supported by the voluntary contributions of their own members. We think that each group should soon achieve this ideal; that any public solicitation of funds using the name of Alcoholics Anonymous is highly dangerous, whether by groups, clubs, hospitals, or other outside agencies; that acceptance of large gifts from any source, or of contributions carrying any obligation whatever, is unwise. Then too, we view with much concern those A.A. treasuries which continue, beyond prudent reserves, to accumulate funds for no stated A.A. purpose. Experience has often warned us that nothing can so surely destroy our spiritual heritage as futile disputes over property, money, and authority.

The content of the essay for tradition 7 addresses all aspects of the long form. The rationale for the statements in the long form is outlined in the essay.

8. Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever nonprofessional, but our service centers may employ special workers.

8. - Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever non-professional. We define professionalism as the occupation of counseling alcoholics for fees or hire. But we may employ alcoholics where they are going to perform those services for which we might otherwise have to engage nonalcoholics. Such special services may be well recompensed. But our usual A.A. "12th Step" work is never to be paid for.

The essay comprehensively covers the statements in the long form of tradition 8.

9. AA as such ought never be organized; but we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.

9. - Each A.A. group needs the least possible organization. Rotating leadership is the best. The small group may elect its secretary, the large group its rotating committee, and the groups of large metropolitan area their central or intergroup committee, which often employs a full-time secretary. The trustees of the General Service Board are, in effect, our A.A. General Service Committee. They are the custodians of our A.A. Tradition and

the receivers of voluntary A.A. contributions by which we maintain our A.A. General Service Office at New York. They are authorized by the groups to handle our overall public relations and they guarantee the integrity of our principle newspaper, the A.A. Grapevine. All such representatives are to be guided in the spirit of service, for true leaders in A.A. are but trusted and experienced servants of the whole. They derive no real authority from their titles; they do not govern. Universal respect is the key to their usefulness.

The essence of tradition 9 is in the essay, but each specific statement is not represented. **The bolded section IS stated in the essay**, the non bolded statements are not in the essay. The essay is primarily focused on the absence of organization.

10. Alcoholics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues; hence the AA name ought never be drawn into public controversy.

10. - No A.A. group or member should ever, in such a way as to implicate A.A., express any opinion on outside controversial issues -- particularly those of politics, **alcohol reform, or sectarian religion**. The Alcoholics Anonymous groups oppose no one. Concerning such matters they can express no views whatever.

The long form of tradition 10 is comprehensively addressed in the essay. The essay addresses the history of harm from political influences, but does not specifically state alcohol reform or sectarian religion.

11. Our public relations policy is based on attraction rather than promotion; we need always maintain personal anonymity at the level of press, radio, and films.

11. - Our relations with the general public should be characterized by personal anonymity. **We think A.A. ought to avoid sensational advertising. Our names and pictures as A.A. members ought not be broadcast, filmed, or publicly printed.** Our public relations should be guided by the principle of attraction rather than promotion. There is never need to praise our selves. We feel it better to let our friends recommend us.

The essay states that "being in the public eye is hazardous, especially for us". But it does not state that "our names and pictures as AA members ought not be broadcast, filmed, or publicly printed". However, the short form of the tradition includes that. All other aspects of the long form of tradition 11 are covered in the essay.

12. Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our traditions, ever reminding us to place principles before personalities.

12. - And finally, we of Alcoholics Anonymous believe that the principle of anonymity has an immense spiritual significance. It reminds us that we are to place principles before personalities; that we are actually to practice genuine humility. **This to the end, that our great blessings may never spoil us; that we shall forever live in thankful contemplation of Him who presides over us all.**

The essay states: "moved by the spirit of anonymity, we try to give up our natural desires for personal distinction as AA members" this depicts the directive in the long form that "we are actually to practice a genuine humility". The last sentence (bolded) is not not addressed in the essay.

Literature Item W: Consider the development of a draft 5th Edition of the Big Book, Alcoholics Anonymous, noting past Advisory Actions

This item reads as

“Consider the development of a draft Fifth Edition of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, noting past Advisory Actions.”

So, this item is to begin the process of getting a fifth edition of the Big Book drafted and adhering to the past advisory actions as a part of its development.

But this begs the question, what are the past advisory actions that are to be adhered to?

Well, these past advisory actions are that all the following parts of the Big Book stay the same and do not change.

The first 164 pages

The preface

The forwards

The Doctor's Opinion

Doctor Bob's Nightmare

And the **Appendices**

These advisory actions were put in place in 1995 and have been continued each year since, which is why the 4th edition had no changes to any of these parts of the Big Book.

Now, there are separate agenda items that address altering the **Appendices and the first 164 pages, but the reasoning for not including all these considerations in a single agenda item that would alter the Appendices and begin the development of a fifth edition, is because the view from some AA members is that it is time to get the ball rolling on the fifth edition. And the discussion about changing the Appendices and the first 164 pages, which would require undoing the past advisory actions, could potentially sandbag starting to get the fifth edition developed.**

This Motion of developing a 5th edition while adhering to the past advisory actions was brought forward from the Area 29 Committee to the Area 29 Assembly held on December 12, 2020. And an email from Cynthia T, the area 29 delegate, to the conference coordinator Patrick C, was sent explaining how there was substantial unanimity supporting forwarding this motion to the conference coordinator, With only 3 dissenting votes. One of the Conference Agenda Review Committees, Also known as CARC, from area 29 was where this motion had originated. This particular CARC approved this motion and then forwarded it to the area 29 committee.

Furthermore, it was also stated in Cynthia T's email that, “we believe that it is critical that past advisory actions be considered in the discussions, we are there for presenting this motion for inclusion in the 71st GSC Agenda.”

Area 29 strong language of the consideration of the past advisory actions as being “critical” to the development of the 5th edition is a noteworthy part of their motion. This strong language seems to be where the waters could get muddled if the 5th edition, Appendices, and alteration of the first 164pages items were to be a part of the same agenda item.

After receiving the motion from the area 29 assembly, Patrick C then forwarded it to the trustee's literature committee. This committee then discussed this item and in their literature report from January 30, 2021, reported this item would be forwarded off to the conference committee.

Now, a bit of a timeline on the editions of the Big Book. , the first edition was published in 1939. The development of the second edition was decided upon in 1954 at the 4th GSC. The second edition was published in 1955, 16 years after the 1st edition, and 1 year after its development was voted on. Bill W had almost exclusively done all the edits for the second edition himself, which is documented in the archives with a letter from Bill W to Bernard Smith, a non-alcoholic trustee who was the Chairman of the Board and the chairman of the Conference at the time. Then the third edition was voted on to be developed at the 26th GSC in 1974 and was then published in 1976. The publishing of the third edition was 25 years after the second edition was published, and 2 years after it was voted on to be developed at the GSC. The 4th edition was then voted on to be developed in 1997 at the GSC. The 4th edition was then published in 2001, again 25 years after the previous edition was published, and 4 years after it was voted on to be developed at the GSC.

So, recapping, the second edition was published in 1955, 1 year after it was voted on based on edits by Bill Wilson to the First edition stories.

The third edition was published 2 years after it was voted on. And the 4th edition was published 4 years after it was voted on. With 16 years between the publishing of the first and second editions, then 25 years between the publishing of the next 2 editions. This November will mark the 20th year since the publishing of the 4th edition. So, hypothetically, if this agenda item passes and it takes 4 or 5 years for the 5th edition to get published, it would closely align with the time frames of the 2 most recent editions of the Big Book being published.

So, what does this mean? I don't know, it is not for me to say, it is up to each member individually to decide what, if anything, this means, and help express the wishes of the ultimate authority through taking part in our group conscience on this agenda item.

Policy and Admissions Item G: Consider a request that a procedure be drafted for appealing a ruling by a General Service Conference chair.

Background Material Pg. 1021

This motion's intent is for something to be done to guide and clarify the processes and procedures, at the general service conference. As well as, preserve and protect the right of appeal and clarify the role of the Chair at the Conference when they call a conference delegate out of order and another conference delegate would like to appeal the chair's ruling.

So what is the role of the general service conference chair ? Did something happen that caused this motion to be written? Has a conference chair ruled a conference delegate out of order? Who would the conference delegates be appealing to, when they feel they have been unjustifiably called out of order ? Do we need special rules ? Do we need a system or do we leave it up to the chair ? Could it be as simple as stopping a meeting and calling for a vote from the body ? Also who are all the conference delegates ?

The conference delegates consist of, all 21 trustees, 93 delegates and all staff members. The general service conference is chaired by the general service board chair and the General Service office manager. The Conference operates under a modified Robert's Rules of Order and Robert's Rules of order has a general guide for the chairperson's role as well as a process for an appeal for a ruling of the Chair. According to

[RROO](#) - The Chairperson performs an invaluable service by running the business meeting , their main job is to chair the event. The chair person under many occasions at almost every conference "quoted by a past trustee has ruled a delegate out of order. This motion came out of *Area 29 with three delegates from area 81, area 60, and area 65 supporting item. After the last conference, during the trustees voting the Conference chair ruled a delegate out of order and the delegate wanted to appeal the ruling, the conference had no direction from the charter or bylaws on how to proceed.

Robert's Rules of Order speaks to this Issue. The "motion to appeal" is one of the lesser known. It is important to remember as well that the Chair is subject to the authority of the whole group. If the Chair says that a given subject is not relevant to the discussion or refuses to recognize someone who is entitled to speak, any two members can appeal. When that happens, the group makes the decision keeping the power in the hands of the group and ensures that the Chair of the meeting always serves the group. The appeal process is spelled out clearly where any two members have the right to appeal, one member making the appeal and the other seconding, the question is then taken from the Chair and vested in the assembly for final decision. In sum: an appeal from the ruling of the Chair: Can interrupt a speaker who has the floor.

During the conference, all 130 members in attendance have the same right of participation. As of panel 70 the relevant language written on this matter. States if a group wants to make an appeal it reports to the district, the district to the area, the delegates to the trustees the trustees to the board and the board back to the groups. During the conference there is not a current process on who the conference delegates all 130 members to appeal back to as they all have the same right of authority. While page s106 does state that “In keeping with these principles, the Conference may agree to hear Concept V Appeals brought by members of the Conference structure below the Conference level on the inverted triangle. But does not address concept V appeals at the conference. .

- The Concepts provide a wealth of background which support the proposed agenda In reviewing them, Concepts II, III, IV, V, X, and Warranties 1, 3, 5 and 6 all support a procedure to be written. While Concept V guarantees all Conference members the Right of Appeal, which may require a specified process. Bill W. states “Fortunately, we are not obliged to maintain a government that enforces conformity by inflicting punishments. We need to maintain only a structure of service that holds aloft the Traditions, that forms and executes our policies thereunder, and so steadily carries our message to those who suffer.

Let us remember that The Chair is still a member of the Conference and as such does not have unqualified authority over others. When it is perceived that the Chair has exercised such authority, it is incumbent a clear process be established to protect this Warranty 3. The trustees of Alcoholics Anonymous are concerned with everything happening inside and outside A.A. that may affect the health and growth of the movement. However, as the Charter points out, their duties are essentially custodial. Whenever a decision on movement-wide policy is needed, they turn to the Conference. And because trustees are members of the Conference body, they participate in these decisions — but as individual Conference members, not as a group. PG S64 • This motion has a suggested procedure process, but is requesting a procedure be drafted. Area 29, Maryland suggests that this procedure may include that the Chair provide an explanation as to such ruling and the process for challenging a ruling of the Chair as defined in Robert's Rules of Order

. How should that be handled? What is the process involved? What rights do the conference members have? What rights does the Chair have? As of right now there is no answer to this. In the absence of a formal proposal, do you support creating such a procedure? Experience both good and bad remains beneficial to the Fellowship after 85 years of existence, providing we use it to improve our procedures and to bring them more in line with our principles.

Policy/Admissions Item J: Consider requests regarding participation of online groups in the General Service structure.

What is being proposed?

Six proposed agenda items, relating to this topic, were forwarded to the committee, as a group. The proposed items vary, but their common theme is finding a pathway for online meetings to fully participate in the General Service structure.

History

Online meetings were first discussed at the Conference in 1996. The focus of previous actions has been the listing of groups. In 2008 an Advisory Action directed, “...Online Intergroup of A.A. be listed in a new section titled “Online Intergroups” under the section “International Correspondence Meetings....” At present Online meetings can register with GSO and will be assigned a customer ID# (for tracking) under the fictitious Area 95; they can then register with the Online Intergroup, but they remain outside the General Service structure.

The pandemic has brought greatly increased attention to these groups, as many groups have moved from in-person to online meetings and many online only meetings have been formed. Online groups are no longer a novelty, but a common meeting type. The common theme of the six proposed agenda items is the desire to include online groups, as full members, in the General Service structure.

Online Meeting Opportunities

Online meetings have served the pandemic health restrictions, but there are other opportunities. They may be the only way for people with mobility issues to attend meetings. People with different schedules are given the opportunity to attend meetings around the world, in different time zones.

The elderly, those with health needs and those with disabilities are able to go to meetings more often.

The creation of new meetings brings more people to A.A. Online meetings can more easily offer language translation.

Online Meeting Objections

There have also been some issues. Some members are confused by Zoom. Zoom information is often not updated in Directories. It can be difficult to get information on group meeting times, links/ID's and passwords. Now that health restrictions are being eased, many groups are being challenged by the decision to meet in-person or online. Online meetings may replace some previous face-to-face meetings.

Why Action is Needed

In a Grapevine article published in November of 1960, Bill calls us to action, "Nothing matters more to AA's future welfare than the manner in which we use the colossus of modern communication. Used unselfishly and well, it can produce results surpassing our present imagination." Tradition #3 states, "Any two or three alcoholics gathered together for sobriety may call themselves an A.A. group." Tradition #5 says, "Each Alcoholics Anonymous group ought to be a spiritual entity having but one primary purpose – that of carrying its message to the alcoholic who still suffers." Online groups meet those standards. The A.A. Service Manual states, "...the home group affords individual A.A.'s the privilege of voting on issues that affect the Fellowship as a whole; it is the very basis of the service structure." The A.A. virtual population has grown but their voice is not heard through a Delegate. Concept #4 states that, "At all responsible levels, we ought to maintain a traditional "Right of Participation," allowing a voting representation in reasonable proportion to the responsibility that each must discharge." This Concept fairly demands that GSO reach out to online-only groups to give them a voice in the process of determining a solution to this issue.

Area 72, in their proposed agenda item, makes a clear request of GSC. "We look to GSC to explore the pros and cons for options to integrate online-only meetings into and then define a clear path that meets the needs beyond our area and even our region."

Public Information Item E: Consider draft plan to develop podcasts

Background: Feb. 1, 2020

The Trustee's Committee on Public Information discussed a request that a podcast be created to better carry the AA message. At that time, the committee suggested that GSO explore the development of a plan to create a GSO podcast to be brought back to the 2021 Conference Committee on Public Information. They suggested that information such as function, target audiences, participation, possible episode topics and implementation be included.

Background: Jan. 30, 2021

The Committee reviewed the Communications Services Department draft plan to create a podcast and agreed to forward the plan to the 2021 Conference Committee on Public Information. Research on Podcasting was conducted and summarized in a report submitted to the PI Committee in October 2020.

The Digital Production Manager of the Communications Services Department (Tracey G) will be leading a working group which will include members from Grapevine, Staff, Publications and Communication Services

Department to continue the analysis of the development of:

1. A sustainable structure for GSO involvement in podcast media projects
2. A Pilot Podcast

Plan's Items for Consideration for the working group:

- A. Logistics and sustainability such as schedule, format, translation, availability and public accessibility
- B. Content: member stories, unique GSO and AA World Services information, Podcast style: solo, interview, discussion style, etc.

Themes/Topics:

- News from Service Entities
- Highlights from World Conference
- Experiences from GSRs, Delegates, Trustees
- A Grapevine Corner
- An Archives show section

Production:

- Editorial Team
- Broadcast location: an external space or production studio (in house)
- Utilization of technical platforms

Pilot and Beyond:

- A single or multi episode podcast
- Future broadcast of Q&A, interviews, Archives, Working with Professionals within the AA Local Community

Trustees Item A: Consider the revised “Procedures for a Partial or Complete Reorganization of the General Service Board, the A.A.W.S. or AA Grapevine Boards.”

The committee respectfully requests consideration and discussion of the submitted draft revised plan that was forwarded to the Conference Committee on Trustees at the 71st General Service.

- The trustees' committee **agreed to forward** an agenda item to the Conference Report and Charter Committee to amend the sentence in Article 4 of the Current Conference Charter which currently reads:

It will be further understood, regardless of the legal prerogatives of the General Service Board, as a matter of tradition, that a three-quarters vote of all Conference members may bring about a reorganization of the General Service Board and the directors and staff members of its corporate services, if or when such reorganization is deemed essential.

Be amended to read:

It will be further understood, regardless of the legal prerogatives of the General Service Board, as a matter of tradition, that a three-quarters vote of all Conference members **participating in the vote** may bring about a reorganization of the General Service Board and the directors and staff members of its corporate services, if or when such reorganization is deemed essential.

Background on keeping in-line with Concept IV as well as the Legal Counsels findings regarding changes to Article 4

What is counsel's view of the language in Article 4 of the Charter (considering the essay in Concept IV)?

Response: Counsel did review the current bylaws and Conference Charter and Concept IV essay. The documentation supports the following reading: That, in good faith, it would be proper for the trustees not to participate in the vote to reorganize the board, i.e., to recuse themselves. There still must be a vote of three-fourths of the Conference membership, i.e., three-fourths of all registered Conference members minus the recused members, to reorganize. Once the participating voting members of the Conference have voted by three-fourths to reorganize, then the Conference body as a whole (all members participating) under regular order may nominate new trustees, then the current board officially elects the new Class B trustees as its successor membership, followed by election of Class A trustees, etc., following the further steps as outlined in the proposed procedure.

Update to End Note 2 approved in February 2020

- The trustees' committee recommended to the General Service Board that the following text "Until the election, the trustees would still be bound by their Code of Conduct and required to fulfill their fiduciary duties to Alcoholics Anonymous." be added to End Note 2 of the "Procedures for a Partial or Complete Reorganization of the General Service Board, the A.A.W.S. or AA Grapevine Boards."

Trustees Item F: Review the "Statement of Concern" and motion to censure for submission to the 71st General Service Conference

Well hasn't this been a great event so far. So much great information, but we're not quite done yet. I have been asked to give my presentation on:

Trustee: ITEM F: Review the "Statement of Concern and Motion to Censure for Submission to the 71st General Service Conference."

My information was from the Background Material, The Letter itself, and the Service Manual.

From the February 1, 2021 First quarterly meeting General Service board meeting:

"After a floor action and discussion, the General Service Board agreed to forward the Statement of Concern and Motion to Censure the General Service Board to the 2021 Conference Committee on Trustees after legal review and the preparation of additional background."

As members of the 70th General Service Conference (G.S.C.) they felt obligated to express their concerns with respect to an erosion of the General Service Board's (G.S.B.) understanding of and adherence to the Warranties of the G.S.C., and to the Twelve Concepts.

This document is a motion of censure; herein censure is defined as a strong opinion of disapproval. They had stated this is neither crafted as a punitive action, nor designed with a spirit to punish. They believe that every G.S.B. member loves A.A. as much as we do. With respect and gratitude for their dedication and for the hours and days they spend voluntarily to serve the A.A. movement.

They also state at the same time the G.S.B. exerts too little guidance or oversight with respect to policies and management of our operating Boards and Offices.

Here are some points from the letter, With Respect for Conference Committees

□ The 70th General Service Conference Committee on Trustees concluded that a candidate for the Alcoholics Anonymous World Service, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) Board was not eligible. In response, the General Manager communicated to the Conference Committee on Trustees, in writing, that if they should remove this individual from their slate approval, they should also remove his own name from the slate. This was viewed as manipulative. We also find it disturbing that the G.S.B. took no apparent action in response to this act by the General Manager at the following G.S.B. meeting.

□ Another example, the Conference Committee on Trustees: When this Committee submitted its Recommendation for slate approval absent the individual in question, the Chairperson ruled the Recommendation "Out of Order" claiming, the Conference Committee did not have the authority to alter the slate. This was wrong both in fact and in spirit. It was incorrect, in fact because the Conference Committee on Trustees, and Conference, does in fact have the authority as outlined in our Concepts, Service Manual, and the Scope and Procedure of the Conference Committee on Trustees.

Mismanagement of Projects and Funds are in question,

□ Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP)

o The ERP project is well over a year beyond its schedule, and an unknown cumulative amount of money over budget. The rumor it is was least \$800,000 over budget as of the April 2020.

*At the G.S.C. in May, and at a special finance report in August 2020, three delegates requested details regarding the original signed scope, schedule and budget. Nobody from the Office or G.S.B. was able to answer this. The General Manager promised to locate and communicate this information

□ "Eighth Floor" project:

o When the Eighth Floor Capital Improvement project was originally proposed, it was slated to use money only from the Operation Account, not the Reserve Fund. When COVID-19 halted in person construction work, eighth floor work ceased. Subsequently the Operating Account decreased dramatically, resulting in the Reserve Fund Draw Down. The month following the three million dollars draw down, from which money was transferred to the general fund (operating fund), eighth floor work resumed.

Another point is the Lack of Financial Transparency (and transparency in general)

□ While technically the money in our funds belongs to our corporations, spiritually they belong to the Fellowship. After having approved the drawn down of up to 4.5 million dollars (two draw-downs) there is still no clear accounting to the Fellowship about how this money was spent. It is true that there is general, and somewhat vague, reporting - but this leads us to ask "where the actual reporting is." Apparently, there is an unaudited and more detailed draw down reporting in existence, however this has not been broadly shared with the G.S.C.

There is also, the Erosion of Office Morale and Office Management

□ An indication that office managerial practices are in need of attention can be seen in the rate of turnover. During the past four to five years, perhaps six executive assistants, four CFOs/Acting CFOs, and third or more office personnel have turned over.

□ Retirement Program

20 G.S.O. and the Grapevine employees accepted the retirement offer. The average tenure within the offices was 26 years, with a high of 38 years. The senior staff person, now, has been with us for only seven years. This is a dramatic departure of history, culture, knowledge and tradition and a serious and significant wound. They just do not understand how this vast departure of history, knowledge, and culture was permitted.

The PROS & CONS:

PRO:

- This would settle or answer many questions that been raised about the actions and the conduct of the G.S.B. We should act like that A.A. future and on members lives depend on the action of our Trusted Servants. And allow for more transparency in the future.

CON:

- This would bring to light any faults of our trusted servants. And put in the record of any possible mismanagement of the G.S.B. and our Corporations. This may lead people to believe of AA ineffectiveness and lividity of its program. And possibility legal actions to those who had mismanaged the Corporations funds.

Thank you for allowing me to participate in this great event.

Love & Service, Ryan